spins around once about every 25 days, but at its poles the Sun rotates once on its axis every 36 Earth days. Most of the materials are pulled toward the centre to form our Sun. The Sun alone accounts for 99.8% of the mass of the entire solar system.

Like all stars, the Sun will someday run out of energy. When the Sun starts to die, it will swell so big that it will engulf Mercury and Venus and maybe even Earth. Scientists predict that the Sun is a little less than halfway through its lifetime and will last another 6.5 billion years before it shrinks down to be a white dwarf.

2.7 The Planets

The word planet in Greek means 'wanderer'. Planet is the celestial body which does not have light or heat of its own. A planet should possess the following qualities:

a. It should orbit around the sun.
b. It should not be a satellite of any planet
c. Due to its own mass and self-gravity, it should get a spherical shape and
d. Any other celestial body should not cross in its orbit.

The planets are classified in order of their distance from the sun and based on their characteristics. They are:

1. **The inner planets** or terrestrial planets or rocky planets. Mercury, Venus, Earth and Mars are called inner or terrestrial planets.
2. **The outer planets** or gaseous planets or giant planets. Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune are called outer or gaseous planets.

Each planet spins on its own axis. This movement is called rotation. One rotation makes one 'planet day'. The planets moving around the sun is called revolution or a 'planet-year'.

Planets in the Solar System

The Mercury

Mercury is the nearest planet to the sun and it is the smallest planet in the solar system. It does not have any satellite. It rotates on its own axis in 58.65 earth days while it takes 88 Earth days to complete one revolution around the sun. Mercury is 0.4 astronomical units away from the Sun. The sunlight takes 3.2 minutes to travel from the Sun to Mercury. Mercury is the second hottest planet though it is nearest to the sun.

The Venus

'Venus' is the second nearest planet to the sun. It is also called as **'Earth's Sister'** planet due to its similar size and mass as that of our Earth. It is the hottest planet in the solar system and experiences a mean surface temperature of 462°C. It is popularly known as **"Morning star and Evening star"** It is seen in the east sky before sunrise (dawn) in the morning and in the west sky after the sunset (twilight). It rotates clockwise i.e. east to west direction on its own axis. The rotation and orbit of the Venus are unusual in several ways. Venus is one of just two planets that rotate from east to west. Only Venus and Uranus have this 'backwards' rotation. It completes one rotation in 243 Earth days which is the longest day of any planet in our solar system. The Venus takes 224.7 Earth days to complete one revolution around the sun, and it has no natural satellites. Venus is 0.7 astronomical units away from the sun. The sunlight takes 6 minutes to travel from the sun to Venus.

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